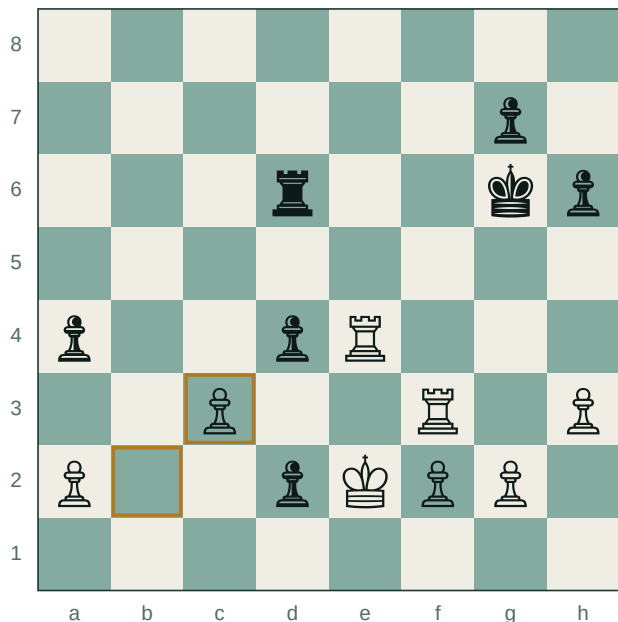


Promotion combinations: Black, move 38

Promotion combinations

Black to move



Previous move: 38.bxc3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

38...dxc3 39. Rd3 Rxd3 40. Kxd3 d1=Q+

38...dxc3 The pawn captures the pawn on c3. Recorded reply: **39.Rd3**.

39...Rxd3 The rook captures the rook on d3. Recorded reply: **40.Kxd3**.

40...d1=Q+ Check restricts White to 3 legal replies here. The pawn becomes a queen.

At the end, nominal material is White 9 / Black 13 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +9. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +9: the balance goes from -5 to +4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Always inspect stalemate and underpromotion resources. A queen is usually strongest, but the exact position determines the choice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An advanced pawn can turn a tactical sequence into a new queen or another useful piece. Promotion may occur with capture or check, and the choice of piece can change the outcome.

HOW TO LOOK

Calculate the pawn's route, the safety of the promotion square, and whether the new piece can survive or give a decisive check.

The defending king is on e2. Geometrically undefended: rook on e4. Check for tactical protection.